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Teaching philosophy statement

Economics as Infrastructure for Thinking

My goal is not to move students through a syllabus. It is to give them a durable way of analyzing real-world problems, whether those problems involve a policy debate they read about or a career decision they will face in five years. I treat economic intuition as an everyday tool, and I build courses that make that tool tangible from the first week. On the first day of class, I survey my students to learn about their specific career ambitions and interests. I then tailor lectures and case studies to match their fields. By aligning economic theory with their professional goals, I ensure the material is both engaging and directly applicable to their futures.

What the Classroom Actually Looks Like

In the most recent section of Principles of Macroeconomics at Rutgers University (Spring 2026) I operated on the principle that structure is a form of care. Because students in that section are often balancing side jobs alongside coursework, I designed the course so that the stakes of any single assignment were not the only deciding factor. Eleven homework assignments (30% of the grade) with the lowest score dropped: a cushion for the unpredictable. Pre-class tutorial quizzes (10%) are due before each lecture and can be taken twice at no penalty, to make sure that students come prepared.

Exams (60%) are weighted asymmetrically: the highest score carries 25%, the second 20%, and the lowest 15%. This structure rewards a student who has a terrible week during the first exam but masters the material by the end. I tell students explicitly: one hard stretch does not define your grade. That message matters to the working adults and first-generation students who populate many of my sections.

My most recent Spring 2026 evaluations (mean teaching effectiveness: 4.75/5.0, against a department mean of 4.42) suggest the approach lands.

Assessment as Feedback, Not Just Evaluation

I treat assignments as diagnostics, not just for students, but for my own teaching. The unlimited-attempt homework format is the clearest expression of this: the goal is not to catch a student making a mistake once, but to fix my own delivery style. I write detailed rubrics and return graded work quickly. Spring 2026 evaluations scored prompt return of assignments at 4.75/5.0, because feedback that arrives two weeks late has lost most of its instructional value.

I am equally deliberate about transparency. Grading criteria are posted at the start of the term, and I hold office hours specifically around exams to walk students through what I am looking for. The evaluation item “course assignments accurately reflected material taught” scored 4.75/5.0 in Spring 2026, which tells me the alignment between what we covered and what I asked students to demonstrate holds.

Equity and Universal Design

My students balance side jobs, caregiving responsibilities, and varying levels of prior economics training. My course design accommodates this heterogeneity. All materials comply fully with the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), and I build in flexible pathways: retakes, dropped scores, asynchronous recordings, as default features rather than exceptions. I have found that what is designed as accommodation for one student typically improves the experience for everyone.

I actively survey students early in the term not just for contextual material but to identify who may need additional support. I hold office hours on a schedule that works for evening students, and I track engagement data in the LMS to reach out proactively to students who go quiet.

Learning Outcomes and What I Am Building Toward

By the end of a course with me, I want students to be able to do three things they could not do before: read a piece of economic news and identify the mechanism behind it, construct a simple model that captures the trade-off in a real-world decision, and articulate why a policy might produce unintended consequences. Students who can do these things are better prepared for careers in business, public service, healthcare administration, law, and a dozen others.

I treat teaching as a practice that develops over time. I read student evaluations carefully every semester, not to protect my scores but to understand what did not land and why. When a student notes that my suggestions for improvement could be more specific, I take that seriously. The goal is not to be a good teacher in a fixed sense but to keep getting better at it.